

Session 4: The Birth of Esau and Jacob

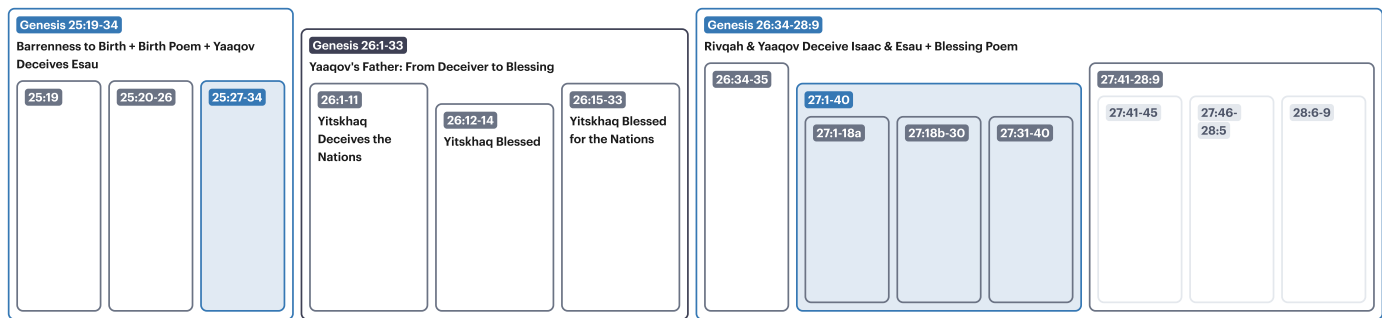
Key Takeaways

- The Yaaqov story offers a raw look at human nature, with deception central to each of its three movements.
- Yaaqov’s story is a tragedy marked by his repeated scheming attempts to secure blessing for himself instead of trusting God and extending blessing to those around him.
- God’s words mark Yaaqov as the one chosen to carry forth the promise of blessing, but from the moment of his birth, Yaaqov’s character is shrouded in ambiguity and doubt.

The Literary Design of the Yaaqov Story

Part 1: Genesis 25:19-28:9

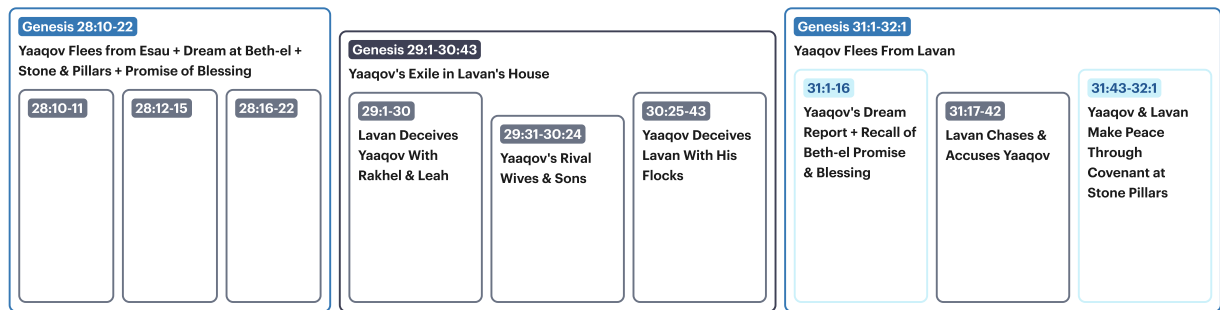
Yaaqov’s deception, sibling rivalry and division, and Yaaqov’s exile.



Genesis 25:19-28:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Part 2: Genesis 28:10-32:1

Yaaqov in exile: deception, sibling rivalry and division, and Yaaqov's flight.



Genesis 28:10-32:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

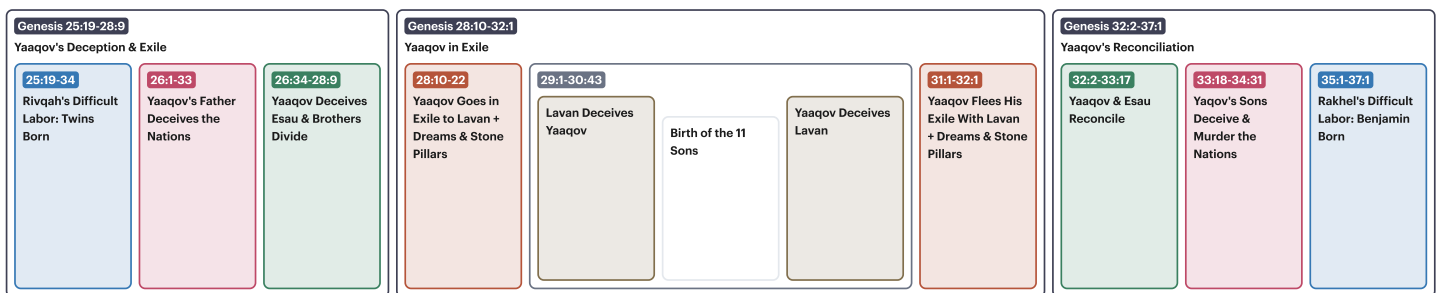
Part 3: Genesis 32:1-37:1

Yaaqov returns from exile, reconciles with Esau, sons' deception and violence.



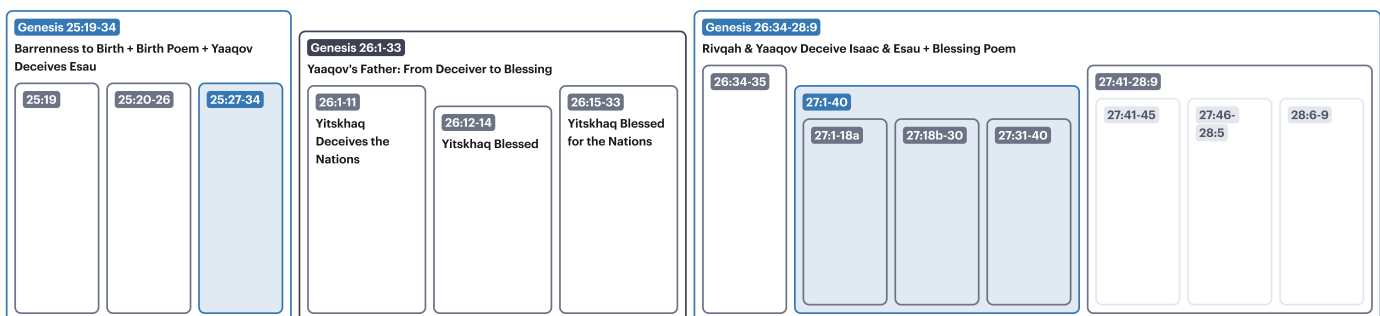
Genesis 32:1-37:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Once we see how the Yaaqov story is organized into three larger bundles, the overall design shape also shows an inverse symmetrical strategy.



Genesis 25:19-37:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

A Deceiver Born and Exiled



Genesis 25:19-28:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

This opening part of the Yaaqov story is made up of three larger literary units with a symmetrical design. The opening section recounts the boys' birth and their first rivalry (Gen. 25:19-34), and these events anticipate the even greater deception and rivalry that explodes in the final section (Gen. 27:34-28:9). In the center we find the story of Yitskhaq, which is itself a three-part symmetrical unit, where Yitskhaq's deception mirrors the deception of his son in the outer units.

Genesis 25:19-34

- Yaaqov (יעקב) is named because he grabs Esau's "heel" (עקב)
- Esau is born hairy and hunts animals

- Yaaqov tricks Esau out of his firstborn right (בכרה)
- “Two nations are in your womb, the greater will serve the littler”

Genesis 26:1-33

- **26:1-11** Yitskhaq deceives Avimelek regarding Sarah
- **26:12-14** Yahweh blesses Yitskhaq in the land
- **26:15-33** Avimelek makes a covenant of peace with Yitskhaq to be included in the blessing

Genesis 26:34-28:9

- Rivqah and Yaaqov trick Yitskhaq to get Esau’s blessing (ברכה)
- Yaaqov is disguised in animal hair to imitate Esau
- “Isn’t he rightly named ‘Yaaqov’?! He’s deceived me two times, taking my firstborn right (בכרה) and my blessing (ברכה)!”
- “May the peoples become your servant ... and your mother's sons bow down to you.”

Genesis 25:19-28:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The Birth and Rivalry of the Brothers

¹⁹ And these are the **birth** -generations (תולדות) of **Yitskhaq**,
son of Avraham:
Avraham
 caused the **birth** (הוליד) of **Yitskhaq**

²⁰ **and Yitskhaq was a son of forty years**
 a when he took Rivqah,
 b the daughter of **Bethuel the Aramean**
 c of Paddan-aram,
 b' the sister of **Lavan the Aramean**,
 a' to be his wife.
 a ²¹ And **Yitskhaq petitioned Yahweh** on behalf of his wife,
 b because **she was barren** ;
 a' and **Yahweh was petitioned by him**
 b' and **Rivqah his wife conceived** .

²² And they struck one another, the sons within her,
and she said, “If it is this way, what is this ... me? (למה זה)”
 and **she went to inquire of Yahweh** .

²³ **And Yahweh said** to her,

- a "Two nations are in your womb;
- a' and two peoples (לאם) will be separated from your guts;
- b and a people (לאם) will be stronger than a people (לאם);
- b' and the great one shall serve the little one."

24 And when her days were fulfilled (מלא) to give birth (ללדת), behold, there were twins (תומם) in her womb.

- a 25 And the first (ראשון) came out red,
- b all over like a garment of hair (שער);
- c and they called his name: Esau (עשו).
- a 26 And afterward (אחרי כן) there came out his brother
- b and his hand was grabbing the heel (עקב) of Esau,
- c and he called his name Yaaqov (יעקב);

and Yitskhaq was a son of sixty years when she gave birth (בלדת) to them.

Genesis 25:19-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Jacob (2021).

The Birth Generations of Yitskhaq

This notice in Genesis 25:19 is a macro-structural device in the Genesis scroll. The phrase appears 10x in the scroll, and it signals that the story is progressing to the next generation of God's chosen family, the line selected for blessing.

The following chart shows the progression.

God Blesses the Chosen One, Who Eventually Fails or Just Dies	God Chooses One From the Next Generation of Brothers Who Then Separate, Usually to the East	Toledot Notice	Genealogy of the Non-Chosen & the Chosen	Selection and Blessing of the Next Generation
Humanity	Gen. 1:26-28 God chooses humans, not animals	Gen. 2:4 "These are the birth generations of the skies and the land ..."		Gen. 1:26-28 Humans blessed

The Birth Generations of Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

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Gen. 2-3 Adam & Eve	Gen. 4 God chooses Hevel, then Seth, not Cain	Gen. 5:1 "This is the scroll of the birth generations of 'adam ..."	Gen. 4:17-18 Cain's line Gen. 5:1-32 Seth's line	Gen. 9:1 Noah's blessing
Gen. 6-9 Noah & wife	Gen. 6:8-9 God chooses Noah and his family, not the generation of the flood	Gen. 6:9 "These are the birth generations of Noah ..."		Gen. 9:26 Shem's blessing
Gen. 9:1-17 Shem	Gen. 9:18-29 God chooses Shem, not Yapheth or Ham	Gen. 10:1 "These are the birth generations of the sons of Noah, Shem ..."	Gen. 10 Noah's sons	Gen. 11:27-32 Terakh
Gen. 11:27-32 Terakh	Gen. 12:1-6 God chooses Avram, not Nahor or Haran	Gen. 11:27 "These are the birth generations of Terakh ..."	Gen. 11:10-26 Shem's line	Gen. 12:1-6 Avram
Gen. 11-24 Avraham & Sarah	Gen. 25:1-18 God chooses Yitskhaq, not Yishmael or the sons of Qeturah	Gen. 25:12 "These are the birth generations of Yishmael"	Gen. 25:12-18 Yishmael's line	Gen. 25:5-11 Yitskhaq
<i>The Birth Generations of Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>				

This narrative momentum prepares the reader to expect that Yitskhaq's story will also replay this cycle. We expect the birth of siblings, one of whom will be chosen and the other not, and we expect this will separate the family instead of uniting them.

Remember, all of this momentum is generated out of the promise of Genesis 3:15, which says there will come from the lineage of Eve a future seed who will encounter hostility from the snake and the snake's seed. However, Eve's seed will fatally wound the snake and be wounded by the snake.

Genesis 3:15 Instructor's Translation

And I will set hostility
between **you** and **the woman** ,
and between **your seed** and **her seed** ;
he will **strike** your head
and **you** will **strike** his heel.

Like Father Abraham, Like Son Yaaqov

Yitskhaq's story takes up the early part of Yaaqov's story. He features as a character in only chapters 25-28 and then is absent from the narrative. He is a transition figure in the Genesis scroll, which focuses mainly on Abraham and Yaaqov.

However, Yitskhaq is a key link in the narrative argument about this family whom God has chosen as his vehicle to restore the Eden blessing to the nations. Yitskhaq's story will replay many of the core themes from his father's story, while anticipating many of the themes from Yaaqov's story to come.

Links Back to the Avraham Narratives	Genesis 25:19-34	Links Forward to Yaaqov Narratives
Gen. 25:12 "These are the generations of Ishmael ..."	Gen. 25:19a "These are the generations of Yitskhaq, son of Avraham ..."	Gen. 37:1 "These are the generations of Yaaqov ..."
Gen. 24:1-67 Avraham's servant meets Rivqah and Lavan and asks that she can marry Yitskhaq	Gen. 25:20 Yitskhaq was 40 when he took Rivqah, daughter of Bethuel the Aramean from Paddan-aram, sister of Lavan the Aramean as a wife	Gen. 29:31 Yaaqov will go to Paddan-aram to work for Lavan in order to marry the daughters of Lavan
Gen. 11:30 Sarai was barren (עקרה)	Gen. 25:21 Rivqah is barren (עקרה)	Gen. 29:31 Rakhel will be barren (עקרה)
Gen. 16-17 Sibling conflict between parents before birth (Hagar & Sarah)	Gen. 25:22, 26 Sibling conflict between the children during birth	Gen. 27, 32-33 Two sons will live in conflict after their birth
Gen. 16, 21 Avraham's two rival wives birth two rival nations :	Gen. 25:23 "two nations are in your womb" = Yitskhaq's two	Gen. 29-30 Yaaqov's two rival wives (whose favor with
<i>Like Father Avraham, Like Son Yaaqov.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

Links Back to the Avraham Narratives	Genesis 25:19-34	Links Forward to Yaaqov Narratives
Israel and the Ishmaelites, which upsets the order of firstborn	rival sons birth two rival nations that upset the order of firstborn	Yaaqov upsets the order of the firstborn) birth rival tribes : Judah and Joseph, which upsets the order of firstborn
Gen. 16, 21 Avraham's older son Ishmael will serve the younger Yitskhaq	Gen. 25:23 "the older will serve the younger"	Gen. 29-30 Yaaqov will eventually overcome Esau but only after his own term of "service" to the elder Lavan
	Gen. 25:27-28 Esau is a hunter in the field, while Yaaqov is a man of the tents	Gen. 29-31 Yaaqov will spend his 20 years serving Lavan "in the field"
Gen. 21-22 Hagar loves Ishmael, Sarah loves Yitskhaq, and Avraham loves them both	Gen. 25:27-28 "... Yitskhaq loved firstborn Esau ... but Rivqah loved second born Yaaqov"	Gen. 29:30-31 "Yaaqov loved Rakhel [second born] more than Leah [firstborn]"
<i>Like Father Avraham, Like Son Yaaqov. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>		

"These parallels are sufficiently close to suggest that they are not coincidental. The history of Isaac's family is being deliberately compared with that of Abraham. And if this is so, special attention needs to be paid to the divine oracle summarizing the future career of Esau and Jacob in 25:23, for this occupies a position analogous to the promises made to Abraham in 12:1-3. The latter passage is of cardinal importance not just for the Abraham cycle but for the whole Pentateuch whose theme it states. Here 25:23 is similarly programmatic: it announces the God-determined career of Jacob to be one of conflict culminating in ultimate triumph."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1994). [Word Biblical Commentary, Volume 2: Genesis 16–50](#). Word. 173.

From Barrenness to Birth

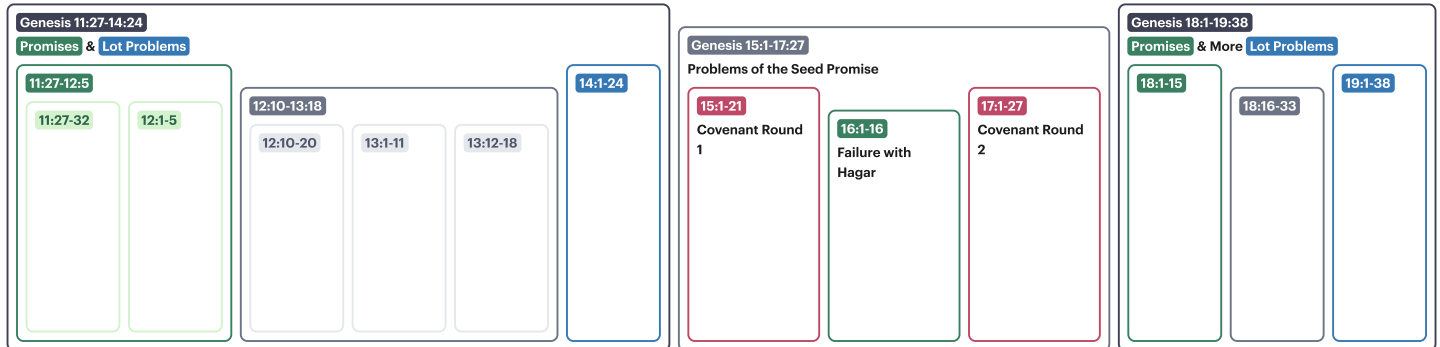
Genesis 25:21 Instructor's Translation

And **Yitskhaq petitioned Yahweh** on behalf of his wife, because she was **barren**; and **Yahweh was petitioned by him** and Rivqah his wife **conceived**.

This story recalls the crisis that Yitskhaq's parents faced at the beginning of their story. Sarah's inability to have children stood in tension with God's promise to bless their family and make them into a great nation. Now God's blessing on Yitskhaq (Gen. 25:11) stands in tension with Yitskhaq and Rivqah's inability to produce children.

However, in contrast to Abraham and Sarah, Yitskhaq and Rivqah quickly find a solution to this crisis: they turn to Yahweh in prayer. However, even this redemptive breaking of the generational chain does not prevent their children from replaying the separation of their ancestors.

The Yitskhaq and Yaaqov story opens with a crisis of fertility on purpose. It goes back to a key theme in the opening movement of the Abraham story.



Genesis 11:27-19:38. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 11:30 Instructor's Translation

Sarai was barren; she had **no child (יֶלֶד)**.

Genesis 16:1 Instructor's Translation

Now Sarai, Abram's wife had borne him **no child (יֶלֶד)**, and she had an Egyptian maid whose name was Hagar.

Genesis 18:10-12 Instructor's Translation

¹⁰ And he said,
 "I will surely return to you at the time of life
 and look, **Sarah your wife will have a son!**"
 Now, Sarah was hearing this at the door of the tent,
 and it was behind him.
¹¹ Now, Abraham and Sarah were old,
 going on in years.
 There had stopped for Sarah the way of women,
¹² and Sarah laughed within herself, saying,
 "After I have become worn out,
will I have Eden (= "delight"),
 and my master, being old?"

Yitskhaq and Rivqah's story has the same theme and vocabulary as Abraham and Sarah's story. This is obviously intentional. And the similarities go even further back. The Eden story begins with the same crisis, but in this case, it features a dry and barren desert unable to produce any plants or seed.

And no bush of the field was yet in the land
and no plant of the field yet sprouted (צמח)

No Water

for Yahweh Elohim had not caused rain upon the land

Human + Ground

and human there was not for working the ground

Water + From the Ground

but a spring would go up from the ground
and it would water all the face of the ground

Human + From the Ground

and Yahweh Elohim formed the human as dust from the ground
and he blew in his nostrils the breath of life
and the human became a living being

Plants + Sprout + From the Ground

and Yahweh Elohim planted a garden in Eden, facing east
and he placed there the human whom he formed
and Yahweh Elohim caused to sprout (צמח) from the ground
every tree, desirable for seeing and good for eating
and the tree of life was in the middle of the garden
and the tree of knowing good and bad

Genesis 2:4-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021)

This narrative also begins with infertility, focusing on the land's inability to produce plants without water. Notice the reversal from barren desert to garden signaled by the words "sprout" and "Eden." This sets up a narrative pattern that carries our expectations into the Yitskhaq story.

Eden Story (Genesis 2-3)	Sarah's Story (Genesis 12-21)	Rivqah's Story (Genesis 25-28)
Begins with barren desert	Begins with "barrenness" — 'aqar ah (ה עקר) = "without root"	Begins with "barrenness" — 'aqar ah (ה עקר) = "without root"
God provides water and infuses the dust with divine breath	God "visits" (פקד) Sarah	God is "petitioned" — 'atar (עתר) — by Yitskhaq
Result: Eden ! Trees, sprouting, and life!	Result: Pregnancy = Eden ! (see Gen. 18:12) A son !	Result: Pregnancy and two sons !
From Barrenness to Life. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

Two Brothers in the Womb

The birth oracle in Genesis 25:23 is cryptic and full of ambiguities that link back to earlier narratives of sibling rivalry, but it also points forward to the Yaaqov story.

Genesis 25:23 Instructor's Translation

Two nations are in your womb;
and two peoples (לָאָם) will be separated from your guts;
and a people (לָאָם) will be stronger than a people (לָאָם);
and the great one shall serve the little one.

The oracle (Gen. 25:22-23) Rivqah receives about the nations "crushing one another" in her womb is cryptic and has been crafted with an eye toward multiple other poems in Genesis as well as the larger themes at work in Genesis 1-24 and 25-50.

Genesis 1-24	The Birth Oracle in Genesis 25:23	Genesis 26-50
Two sons represent two nations • Cain = City of Cain vs. Seth = Sethites • Japeth, Shem, Ham all = nations • Avraham = Hebrews // Lot = Ammonites, Moabites • Ishmael = Midianites // Yitskhaq =	Two nations are in your womb,	Sons represent tribes • 12 sons of Yaaqov = 12 tribes of Israel • Esau = Tribes of Edom
Two Brothers in the Womb. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

Genesis 1-24	The Birth Oracle in Genesis 25:23	Genesis 26-50
Hebrews • Esau = Edom // Yaaqov = Israel		
Two brothers who represent people groups will separate (פָּרַד) outside of Eden. • The River from the garden separates outside Eden • Cain and Abel/Seth separate outside of Eden • Japeth, Shem, Ham separate outside the ark • Avraham and Lot separate outside the hill country • Ishmael and Yitskhaq separate outside Avraham's tent • Esau and Yaaqov separate outside Rivqah's womb	and two people groups from your loins will be separated	Brothers separate outside of "Eden" Gen. 36 Israel and Edom will settle in opposite regions
One brother/people serves their brother/people Gen. 9:25-27 Cursed be Canaan, a servant of servants to his brothers. Blessed be Yahweh, God of Shem, and may Canaan be his servant. May God enlarge Japeth, and may he dwell in the tents of Shem, and may Canaan be his servant.	and a people will be stronger than a people and a greater will serve a smaller	One brother/people serves their brother/people • Gen. 29-31 Israel serves Lavan the Aramean • Gen. 37-42 Joseph's dream that his brothers will bow down and serve him • Gen. 49 Yaaqov's blessing on Judah: Your brothers will bow down to you • Exod. 1-15 Egypt (son of Ham) enslaves Israel (son of Shem)
<i>Two Brothers in the Womb.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

Let's look at the phrase "nations will be separated from your loins." This image connects to the entire web of Eden blessing themes, such as the divine river that left the garden and separated outside to water the nations (פָּרַד, Gen. 2:10). This river is set on analogy to the womb of all the matriarchs whose sons "separate" (פָּרַד) outside the womb and end up in conflict with each other.

Look at the riddle of the final line: *The greater one / he will serve / the younger one.*

Hebrew word order allows for the subject to come before or after the verb, as well as the object. This means the final line could be read in two opposite ways, and both seem intended.

- Option 1: The greater one will serve the younger one.
- Option 2: The greater one, the younger one will serve.

This ambiguity allows for the changing power dynamics in the brothers' relationship throughout the narrative. Yaaqov will deceive and usurp Esau's role as the firstborn, but then Esau's anger and power will force Yaaqov into exile, where he must serve Lavan for twenty years and then come back to present himself to Esau as "your servant" ([Gen. 33:5](#)). While Yaaqov does prevail over Esau in the end, it is only by becoming a slave himself as a consequence of his sins against his brother (see Yair Zakovitch, [Jacob](#), p. 16-17).

This ambiguity also previews the future relations between the nations of Israel and Edom, especially in 1-2 Kings (note that each son is called "a nation" in the womb).

Yaaqov: Born a Heel-Grabber

Genesis 25:26 Instructor's Translation

And afterward there came out his brother
and his hand was grabbing the **heel (עקב)** of Esau,
and he called his name **Yaaqov (יעקב)** ;

Yaaqov is born grabbing the heel of his brother, which is a potent image that symbolizes all that is to come in his story. The use of the rare word 'aqev in Genesis opens up a whole series of reflections.

English	Hebrew	Usage in Genesis
heel	‘aqev (עקב)	Gen. 3:15 The snake will strike the heel of the seed (זרע) of the woman. Gen. 25:26 Yaaqov is born grabbing he heel of his brother. Gen. 49:17 Dan will be like a snake on the road, that bites the heel of a horse, causing the rider to fall.
to grab the heel, usurp, trick	‘aqav (עקב)	Gen. 27:36 Isn't he named Yaaqov ? And so he " yaaqov'd "
Yaaqov	yaaqov (יעקב)	
Yaaqov the Heel Grabber. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

English	Hebrew	Usage in Genesis
on account of, because of, lit. “on the heel of”	‘eqev (עקב)	Gen. 22:17-18 “All the nations of the land will discover blessing by means of your seed (זרעך), because of/on account of (עקב) your listening to my voice.” Gen. 26:4-5 “All the nations of the land will discover blessing by means of your seed (זרעך), because of/on account of (עקב) his listening to my voice, and he kept my warning, my commands, my statutes, and my instruction (<i>torah</i>).”
<i>Yaaqov the Heel Grabber</i>. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

There are multiple contrasts at work here.

1. The snake versus the seed of the woman: The Eden story sets up the expectation that people will take up the role of the snake and become hostile toward the one God chooses to bless. The next story, about Cain, Abel, and Seth, dramatizes this tension. The non-chosen brother gives in to the power of the snake (= “sin” in Gen. 4:7), and becomes hostile to the chosen brother. At first, we may think this will be a story with binary character sets: chosen versus non-chosen, good guys versus bad guys.
2. Abraham acts like a snake: In two stories that both replay the story of Adam and Eve’s failure in Eden, Abraham takes on the role of the snake and brings curse on the nations instead of a blessing (see Gen. 12:10-20, 20:1-14).

Avram’s Deception in Genesis 12:10-20	The Snake’s Deception in Genesis 3
Avram relies on his knowledge of what will happen in Egypt instead of trusting God’s promise Gen. 12:11-12 “I know (ידע) that a woman (אשה) beautiful of sight (מראה) you are ... and they will see you (ראה) ... and kill me and let you live (חיה).”	Adam and Eve seek their own knowledge of good and bad, instead of trusting God’s command Gen. 3:6 The woman (אשה) Eve (חוה) “saw (ראה)” the tree of knowing (ידע) good (טוב) and evil, “and it was desirable to the eyes.”
Avram’s deception results in “good” at the expense of Sarai, resulting in plagues on Pharaoh Gen. 12:13 “Say you’re my sister, so that it may be good (טוב), on account of you (בעבורך), and I will live (חיה).”	Adam and Eve’s actions result in curse on the ground Gen. 3:17 “Cursed is the ground on account of you (בעבורך).”
<i>Avraham and Snake’s Deception</i>. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Avram's Deception in Genesis 12:10-20	The Snake's Deception in Genesis 3
Gen. 12:17 "And Yahweh sent plagues upon Pharaoh, on account of Sarai." Avram presents his wife as a "tree of testing" to the Egyptians Gen. 12:14-15 "And the Egyptians saw (ראה) the woman (האשה), that she was beautiful, very ... and she was taken (לקח) to the house of Pharaoh." Gen. 12:17 Yahweh struck/touched (נגע) Pharaoh with great strikes (נגעים).	The snake presents the "tree of testing" to the humans Gen. 3:6 "And the woman (האשה) saw (ראה) that good (טוב) was the tree for eating, and desirable to the eyes ... and she took (לקח)" Gen. 3:3 "... from the tree that is in the middle of the garden we cannot eat from it or touch it (נגע) ."
Pharaoh holds Avram accountable for his deception Gen. 12:18 "And Pharaoh called out to (ויקרא) Abram and said ' What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית) to me? You didn't tell (נגד) me that she was your wife."	God holds Adam and Eve accountable for their action Gen. 3:9 "And Yahweh called out to (ויקרא) the man ..." Gen. 3:13 "And Yahweh said to the woman, ' What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?'" Gen. 3:11 "Who told (נגד) you that you were naked?"
Pharaoh exiles Avram Gen. 12:20 "And Pharaoh commanded (ויצו) ... and sent him away (שלח)."	God exiles Adam and Eve Gen. 2:16 "And Yahweh commanded (ויצו) the human ..." Gen. 3:23 "And Yahweh sent away (שלח) the human from the garden of Eden."
<i>Avraham and Snake's Deception. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

However, Abraham's story has a redemptive arc. A man who once acted like a snake eventually comes to trust God so radically that he will offer up the life of his son in faith that he will receive him back!

The use of the word 'eqev in Gen. 22:18 (along with many other echoes of the Eden failure story) shows that this is Abraham's victory over the snake! This is precisely the meaning of 'eqev that is recalled in the Yitskhaq and Yaaqov story in Gen. 26:4-5.

But the birth of Yaaqov throws a wrench into this mix. What happens when the seed of the woman is born a snake, grabbing the heel?

Reflection Question

Yaaqov's story is marked by schemes and deception. What can we learn about the interplay between God's sovereign purposes and the human partners he's chosen to work through?